describes it as a conscious attempt to embed conservation into the emotional architecture of family life. Sikkimese society, he notes, has always treated mountains, forests, lakes and springs as sacred, and the programme draws directly from that worldview. "Planting trees at the moment of childbirth creates an environmental legacy that grows alongside the child," he says.

What further distinguishes the initiative is the economic incentive that reinforces it. Once the plantation of 108 trees is completed and digitally verified and geo-tagged, an interest-bearing fixed deposit of Rs 10,800 is opened in the child's name under the Sikkim Shishu Samriddhi Yojana. The deposit matures when the child turns 18. As a personal gesture, chief minister Prem Singh Tamang presents families with a certificate signed by him. The passbooks for the fixed deposits also bear his image.



Takeaways

- **The Mero Rukh Mero Santati programme links a child's birth to planting 108 trees in their name**
- **An interest-bearing FD of Rs 10,800 in the child's name incentivises families**
- **Community stewardship strengthens survival rates of fragile plantations**

THE POWER OF 108

Deeply embedded in Buddhist and Hindu traditions, the number 108 symbolises wholeness and continuity. By using a culturally resonant number, officials argue, the programme avoids the abstraction that often plagues environmental policies. "We have used the five colours of the Buddhist flag to mark each plantation, to further the sense of spirituality and involvement as well as help people identify their plantation," says Kshitij Saxena, divisional forest officer, Gangtok. The coloured markers help families locate their saplings and serve as reminders of the trees' larger spiritual and cultural purpose.

PEOPLE AS PROTECTORS

Forest officials acknowledge that long-term survival of plantations has always been a challenge. By transferring emotional and economic ownership to families, the state is effectively decentralising conservation. Parents visit the sites, replace guards if needed and keep watch against grazing or vandalism, often more vigilantly than any official patrol can manage. It improves the survival rates of saplings too.

Experts see in this model a rare convergence of ecology, culture and policy design. Mahendra P. Lama, development economist and senior professor at the Jawaharlal Nehru University in Delhi, calls it a welcome initiative by the government and stresses that maximum participation of common people must be ensured if Sikkim's fragile ecology is to be sustained. For Lama, the strength of the scheme lies in building a social norm where environmental stewardship is woven into everyday life. There is also a quiet economic logic at work. Many parents choose fruit-bearing or flowering species. Over the years, these trees can provide supplementary income, fodder or ecosystem services such as soil stabilisation and water retention.

Mero Rukh Mero Santati was showcased at the UN Climate Change Conference (COP28) in Dubai in 2023 as an example of community-led action, but its real impact is visible in places like Ranka and Reshithang, where parents walk plantation trails as routinely as they walk their fields. Standing among the young trees, Gautam speaks of them with the same protectiveness he reserves for his children. "The trees are now like my children. Much like I will not allow any harm to my two sons, I will protect these trees as well," he says. ■

▶ KARNATAKA

CIVIC RESET

Court-mandated municipal election and new governance structures set stage for Bengaluru's urban overhaul

By **Ajay Sukumaran**

BENGALURU, INDIA'S STORIED TECH CAPITAL, HAS LONG BEEN A PARADOX—a city of innovation and aspiration, yet mired in civic dysfunction. For over five years, residents have navigated crumbling roads, erratic garbage collection and chronic flooding without the guiding hand of an elected municipal body. Now, the Supreme Court has set a firm deadline: by June 30, the Karnataka government must hold long-delayed civic elections in Bengaluru. The order, issued after petitions flagged the inordinate delay, has forced authorities to expedite ward reservations and electoral rolls—and pushed political parties into campaign mode.

The election will unfold against a dramatically altered administrative landscape. Sweeping changes introduced through the Greater Bengaluru Governance Act, passed by the Karnataka assembly in 2025, dismantled the Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike (BBMP), whose 18-year run had rendered it too unwieldy for a fast-expanding city. In its place now stand five municipal